Medieval dynasties

Rajput Kingdoms (c. 8th – 12th century CE)

Overview:
The Rajput Kingdoms emerged in early medieval India as powerful regional states after the decline of the Gurjara-Pratiharas and other early dynasties. The Rajputs, a warrior aristocracy, rose to prominence between the 8th and 12th centuries CE and established numerous kingdoms that shaped the political and cultural landscape of north and western India.

Major Dynasties and Kingdoms:

- Chauhans (Chahamanas): Centered around Ajmer and Delhi. They gained prominence under rulers like Vigraharaja IV and Prithviraj Chauhan, who resisted Muslim invasions but fell to Muhammad of Ghor at the Second Battle of Tarain (1192 CE).
- Rathores: Originally linked with Kannauj, later established themselves in Marwar (Rajasthan). They became important after the fall of the Gahadavalas.
- Chandelas: Ruled Bundelkhand (central India) with their capital at Khajuraho. They are remembered for constructing the famous Khajuraho temples (10th–11th century CE), renowned for their Nagara-style architecture and sculpture.
- Paramaras: Dominated Malwa (central India) with their capital at Dhar. King Bhoja (11th century CE) was their most celebrated ruler, known for his patronage of learning, arts, and architecture.

Geographical Spread:
The Rajput kingdoms largely controlled Rajasthan, Gujarat, Malwa, Bundelkhand, and parts of north India. Their territories often shifted due to wars, alliances, and invasions, but collectively they formed a strong political force in the subcontinent.

Political Features:

- Fragmented political structure: multiple independent kingdoms with frequent rivalries.
- Strongly martial society: emphasis on valor, warfare, and codes of honor.
- Defensive fortifications: built magnificent forts like Chittorgarh, Gwalior, and Ranthambore.
- Resistance against foreign invasions, especially against the Ghaznavids and Ghurids.

Culture and Contributions:

- Patronized temple architecture (Khajuraho, Dilwara temples at Mount Abu, Somnath in Gujarat).
- Promoted literature and learning in Sanskrit and regional languages. King Bhoja of the Paramaras authored scholarly works.
- Encouraged Rajput traditions of chivalry, heroism, and loyalty, which became legendary in later Indian folklore.
- Flourished in art, sculpture, and architecture that reflected both devotion and grandeur.

Decline:
From the late 12th century, the Rajput kingdoms weakened due to:

- Internal rivalries and lack of unity.
- Defeats at the hands of Turkic invaders (notably Muhammad Ghori's victory over Prithviraj Chauhan in 1192).
- The expansion of the Delhi Sultanate, which absorbed many Rajput territories.

Despite this decline, Rajput states continued to survive in Rajasthan and other regions, remaining significant in later centuries.

Chahamanas of Shakambhari (c. 6th – 12th century CE)

Overview:
The Chahamanas, also known as the **Chauhans**, were a prominent Rajput dynasty that ruled parts of Rajasthan and north-western India. Their early capital was at **Shakambhari (modern Sambhar, Rajasthan)**, and later shifted to Ajmer. They rose to prominence between the 6th and 12th centuries CE and played a key role in defending north India from foreign invasions.

Key Rulers and Achievements:

- **Vasudeva (6th century CE):** Considered the founder of the dynasty.
- **Ajayaraja II (1110–1135 CE):** Established Ajmer as the new capital and built the Ajmer fort (later known as Taragarh Fort).
- **Vigraharaja IV (1150–1164 CE):** Expanded the kingdom significantly; patron of art and literature. Built temples and public works.
- **Prithviraj III (Prithviraj Chauhan, 1178–1192 CE):** The most famous Chauhan ruler.
    - Defeated **Muhammad Ghori** at the **First Battle of Tarain (1191 CE)**.
    - Was defeated in the **Second Battle of Tarain (1192 CE)**, leading to the establishment of Muslim rule under the Delhi Sultanate.

Territory:
The Chahamanas controlled **Ajmer, Delhi, and surrounding regions in Rajasthan and Haryana**. Their strategic position made them one of the most powerful Rajput dynasties of north India.

Political Features:

- Asserted independence after the decline of the Gurjara-Pratiharas.
- Maintained strong military traditions and were known for their cavalry and fortifications.
- Engaged in constant conflict with neighboring Rajput dynasties like the Chalukyas and Paramaras.

Cultural Contributions:

- Patronized **temple architecture and Sanskrit literature**.
- Vigraharaja IV is credited with building a temple later converted into the Adhai Din Ka Jhonpra mosque by the Delhi Sultanate.
- Encouraged Rajput traditions of **valor, loyalty, and chivalry**, later immortalized in epics and ballads.

Decline:

- Defeat of **Prithviraj Chauhan in 1192 CE** at the hands of Muhammad Ghori marked the end of their political dominance.
- Their fall opened the path for the **establishment of the Delhi Sultanate** in north India.
- Some Chauhan branches survived in smaller principalities in Rajasthan, such as Bundi and Jhalawar, and remained influential in later Rajput politics.

Rashtrakuta Empire (753 – 982 CE)

Overview:
The **Rashtrakutas** were a powerful dynasty that ruled the **Deccan region** of India between the 8th and 10th centuries CE. They rose to prominence after overthrowing the Chalukyas of Badami and became one of the leading political, military, and cultural powers of early medieval India.

Founding and Rise:

- Founded by **Dantidurga (r. 753–756 CE)**, who defeated the Chalukyas and laid the foundation of Rashtrakuta power.
- Successive rulers expanded their influence both north and south, controlling much of the Deccan plateau.

Key Rulers:

- **Dantidurga (753–756 CE):** Founder; secured control over the Deccan.
- **Krishna I (756–773 CE):** Built the famous **Kailasa temple at Ellora**, a marvel of rock-cut architecture.
- **Dhruva Dharavarsha (780–793 CE):** Defeated the Gurjara-Pratiharas in the north and the Pallavas in the south, extending Rashtrakuta influence.
- **Govinda III (793–814 CE):** Known for his successful northern and southern expeditions; Rashtrakuta power reached its peak.
- **Amoghavarsha I (814–878 CE):** Reigned for a long period; a patron of literature and Jainism. He authored **Kavirajamarga**, the earliest known Kannada literary work.
- **Krishna III (939–967 CE):** The last great ruler; extended control over the south, defeating the Cholas and establishing influence in Tamil Nadu.

Political Significance:

- The Rashtrakutas were one of the three main powers in India during the early medieval period, along with the **Palas of Bengal** and the **Pratiharas of north India**.

- These three dynasties engaged in the **Tripartite Struggle** (8th–10th centuries CE) for control over **Kannauj**, a symbol of supremacy in north India.

Administration and Society:

- Governed through a well-organized **feudal system**, with local chiefs owing allegiance to the king.
- Encouraged trade and commerce; the Deccan was connected to both north and south Indian markets.
- Supported multiple religions, though they were especially close to **Jainism**.

Cultural Contributions:

- Built some of the greatest **rock-cut temples**, most notably the **Kailasa temple at Ellora** (carved out of a single rock, dedicated to Lord Shiva).
- Patronized **literature in Sanskrit and Kannada**.
- Amoghavarsha I was a scholar-king, promoting Kannada literature and Jain philosophy.

Decline:

- After Krishna III's death (967 CE), the empire weakened due to internal conflicts and invasions.
- By 982 CE, they were replaced by the **Later Chalukyas of Kalyani**.

Palas (c. 8th – 11th century CE)

Overview:
The **Pala dynasty** ruled **Bengal and Bihar** from the mid-8th to the 11th century CE. They rose after the decline of local powers and became a major force in eastern India. The Palas were known for their patronage of **Buddhism** and for their role in the **Tripartite Struggle**.

Key Rulers:

- **Gopala (r. 750–770 CE):** Founder, chosen by local chieftains; restored stability in Bengal.
- **Dharmapala (r. 770–810 CE):** Expanded Pala power into northern India, played a leading role in the **Tripartite Struggle for Kannauj** against the Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas.
- **Devapala (r. 810–850 CE):** Pala Empire reached its height; extended control into Assam and parts of Odisha. Patronized Nalanda University.
- **Mahipala I (r. 988–1038 CE):** Revived Pala power after a decline; promoted Buddhism and built monasteries.

Culture and Contributions:

- Great patrons of **Mahayana Buddhism**.

- Supported universities like **Nalanda, Vikramashila, Odantapuri**.
- Sponsored Buddhist art, especially the **Pala School of Sculpture**, known for elegant stone and bronze works.
- Spread Buddhism to Tibet and Southeast Asia.

Decline:

- From the 11th century, weakened by invasions of the **Cholas** and **Kalachuris**.
- Overthrown by the **Sen dynasty** in Bengal by the late 11th century.

Pratiharas (Later Phase, c. 8th – 11th century CE)

Overview:
The **Gurjara-Pratiharas** dominated **western and northern India** between the 8th and 11th centuries CE. They initially served under Harsha's successors but later carved out an independent empire. They became prominent in the **Tripartite Struggle** for Kannauj.

Key Rulers:

- **Nagabhata I (c. 730–760 CE):** Defended against Arab invasions in western India.
- **Vatsaraja (c. 775–805 CE):** Entered the Tripartite Struggle; established Kannauj as an objective of his expansion.
- **Nagabhata II (c. 805–833 CE):** Defeated Dhruva (Rashtrakuta) but later lost ground; expanded territory across Malwa and Gujarat.
- **Mihira Bhoja (c. 836–885 CE):** The most powerful ruler; extended empire from Punjab to central India. Patron of Hinduism, especially Vaishnavism.
- **Mahendrapala I (885–910 CE):** Empire at its peak, controlled much of north India.

Culture and Contributions:

- Known for the **Nagara style of temple architecture** (e.g., temples at Khajuraho built later under Chandellas were influenced by this style).
- Promoted Sanskrit literature; court poets like Rajashekhara flourished.
- Acted as a **barrier against Arab invasions** from Sind.

Decline:

- Constant conflicts with Rashtrakutas and Palas drained resources.
- By the 10th–11th centuries, weakened by Chahamanas, Paramaras, and finally invasions by the Ghaznavids.
- Lost prominence after the rise of regional Rajput kingdoms.

Mahmud of Ghazni (971 – 1030 CE)

Overview:
Mahmud of Ghazni was the most prominent ruler of the **Ghaznavid Empire**, which had its capital at **Ghazni (Afghanistan)**. He is remembered for his **military campaigns into India**, his patronage of art and learning, and the spread of Islam in Central and South Asia.

Political Career and Conquests

- **Came to power in 997 CE** after succeeding his father, Sabuktigin.
- Expanded the Ghaznavid Empire across Afghanistan, eastern Iran, Central Asia, and north-western India.
- Launched **17 military raids into India** (1000–1027 CE).
- Objectives of the raids:
    - Plunder wealth (to fund his empire).
    - Spread political influence in north India.
    - Establish Ghaznavid power and weaken Hindu kingdoms.
- Major targets:
    - Punjab and the north-west frontier.
    - Rich temples and cities like **Thanesar, Mathura, Kannauj, and Somnath**.
- **Somnath raid (1025 CE):** The most famous; looted the wealthy **Somnath temple in Gujarat**, destroying its idol and carrying away immense treasure.

Cultural Role

- Patron of learning, art, and architecture.
- His court at Ghazni was a major cultural center.
- Scholars like **Al-Biruni** (author of *Tahqiq-i-Hind*) and the Persian poet **Firdawsi** (author of *Shahnameh*) flourished under his patronage.
- Spread **Persian culture and Islam** across Central and South Asia.

Significance in Indian History

- His raids caused devastation but also exposed the **wealth of Indian temples and cities**.
- Weakened many north Indian kingdoms, especially the **Pratiharas** and **Chauhans**, paving the way for later Muslim conquests.

- However, he did **not establish permanent rule in India**; his control was limited to Punjab and north-west frontier regions.

Decline and Death

- Died in **1030 CE** at Ghazni.
- After his death, the Ghaznavid Empire weakened and eventually lost much of its territory to the **Seljuk Turks** and later the **Ghurids**.

Muhammad Ghori (1173 – 1206 CE)

Overview:
Muhammad Ghori (also known as Muʿizz al-Dīn Muhammad) was a ruler of the **Ghurid Dynasty** from **Ghor, Afghanistan**. Unlike Mahmud of Ghazni, who raided India mainly for plunder, Ghori's campaigns aimed at **establishing permanent rule**. His victories laid the foundation for the **Delhi Sultanate**.

Early Career and Expansion

- Came to power in **1173 CE**, ruling from Ghazni and Ghor.
- Extended his empire over Afghanistan, Sindh, Punjab, and parts of north India.
- Fought against both **Hindus (Rajputs)** and rival Muslim powers in Central Asia.

Campaigns in India

- **First Battle of Tarain (1191 CE):**
    - Fought against **Prithviraj Chauhan (Chahamana ruler of Ajmer and Delhi)**.
    - Ghori was defeated and forced to retreat.
- **Second Battle of Tarain (1192 CE):**
    - Returned with a stronger, better-organized army.
    - Defeated **Prithviraj Chauhan** decisively.
    - This victory opened the way for **Muslim political dominance in north India**.
- **Battle of Chandawar (1194 CE):**
    - Defeated the **Gahadavala king Jayachandra** of Kannauj.
    - Strengthened his hold over the **Ganga plains**.
- Other Campaigns:
    - Extended control into **Bihar and Bengal** through his general **Bakhtiyar Khalji**, who destroyed **Nalanda University**.

Administration

- Did not rule India directly; instead, appointed trusted generals and governors.
- His most important lieutenant was **Qutb-ud-din Aibak**, who managed his Indian territories and later became the **first ruler of the Delhi Sultanate (Slave Dynasty)** after Ghori's death.

Death

- Assassinated in **1206 CE** while returning from a campaign in Central Asia.
- With his death, the **Ghurid Empire weakened**, but his Indian territories passed to his generals, ensuring continuity of Islamic rule.

Mamluk (Slave) Dynasty – Delhi Sultanate (1206–1290 CE)

Overview:
The **Mamluk Dynasty**, also called the **Slave Dynasty**, was the first ruling house of the **Delhi Sultanate**. It was established by **Qutb al-Din Aibak**, a former slave of Muhammad Ghori. The dynasty lasted from **1206 to 1290 CE** and laid the foundations of Muslim rule in India.

Key Rulers and Contributions

1. **Qutb al-Din Aibak (1206–1210 CE)**

- Founder of the Mamluk dynasty.
- A trusted general of Muhammad Ghori, he became ruler of Delhi after Ghori's death.
- Known as **"Lakhbaksh"** (giver of lakhs) for his generosity.
- Commissioned the construction of **Qutb Minar** (completed later by Iltutmish) and **Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque**.
- Died in 1210 CE due to a polo accident.

2. **Shams al-Din Iltutmish (1211–1236 CE)**

- Consolidated and expanded the Sultanate.
- Defeated rival Turkish chiefs and secured Delhi.
- Recognized by the **Caliph of Baghdad**, giving legitimacy to his rule.
- Completed **Qutb Minar**.
- Introduced administrative reforms, organized **iqta system** (land revenue grants).
- Established Delhi as the capital.
- Nominated his daughter **Razia Sultan** as successor.

3. **Razia Sultan (1236–1240 CE)**

- First and only **woman ruler of Delhi Sultanate**.
- Competent and capable, but faced opposition from nobles (Turkish aristocracy or "Chihalgani").
- Overthrown and killed in 1240 CE.

4. **Ghiyas al-Din Balban (1266–1287 CE)**

- One of the most powerful Mamluk rulers.
- Strengthened the monarchy with the idea of **"Kingship as divine"**.
- Introduced strict court discipline (**Sijda** – prostration before the king, and **Paibos** – kissing the king's feet).
- Suppressed revolts and checked Mongol invasions.
- Built a strong centralized administration, emphasized **law and order**.

Administration and Society

- Adopted the **Iqta system**: nobles collected revenue from assigned lands but maintained troops for the Sultan.
- Strong military focus to defend against internal rebellions and Mongol invasions.
- Persian culture, language, and literature flourished.
- Architecture: Early Indo-Islamic monuments (Qutb Minar, Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque, tomb of Iltutmish).

Decline

- After Balban's death (1287 CE), weak successors failed to control nobles and Mongol threats.
- Dynasty ended in **1290 CE**, replaced by the **Khilji (Khalji) Dynasty**.

Mongol Invasions of India (c. 1221 – 1327 CE)

Overview:

- Mongols, under **Genghis Khan**, first appeared on India's frontier in **1221 CE**, pursuing Khwarazm Shah. They did not stay, but opened the way for repeated raids.
- During the **Delhi Sultanate**, Mongols made frequent attacks on Punjab and north India.
- Major impact under **Alauddin Khilji**, who had to defend against large-scale invasions.

Key Points:

- **Alauddin Khilji (1296–1316):** Repelled several Mongol invasions through strong fortifications and a standing army.
- Introduced **permanent army, branding of horses, cash payments**, partly due to Mongol threat.
- Mongols captured parts of Punjab briefly but were pushed back.
- Mongol threat declined by early 14th century.

Khilji Dynasty (1290 – 1320 CE)

Overview:

- Founded by **Jalaluddin Khilji** (1290 CE).
- Dynasty became famous under **Alauddin Khilji (1296–1316)**, who expanded the empire and introduced economic reforms.

Key Points:

- **Alauddin Khilji:**
    - Expanded empire into Gujarat, Rajasthan, and Deccan (Yadavas, Kakatiyas, Hoysalas, Pandyas).
    - Defeated Mongols repeatedly.
    - Introduced **market reforms**: price control on grains, cloth, horses; maintained huge standing army.
    - Promoted efficient revenue system.
- After his death, weak successors ruled.

Tughlaq Dynasty (1320 – 1414 CE)

Overview:

- Founded by **Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq (1320)**.
- Dynasty is remembered for ambitious experiments and large empire.

Key Rulers:

- **Muhammad bin Tughlaq (1325–1351):**
    - Known for bold but failed experiments:
        - Transfer of capital from Delhi to Daulatabad.
        - Token currency of brass and copper.
        - Large but unsuccessful expeditions (e.g., to Khurasan).
    - His reign saw revolts and decline of central authority.

- **Firoz Shah Tughlaq (1351–1388):**
    - Focused on administration, irrigation, welfare.
    - Built canals, gardens, towns (Firozabad).
    - Patron of architecture (Firoz Shah Kotla).
    - Imposed **Jizya tax** more strictly.
- Later rulers: Weak, unable to stop Timur's invasion (1398).

Sayyid Dynasty (1414 – 1451 CE)

Overview:

- Founded by **Khizr Khan**, after Timur's invasion left Delhi weak.
- Nominally ruled on behalf of Timur's successors.

Key Features:

- Small territory limited to Delhi and nearby regions.
- Weak rulers, no major achievements.
- Marked decline of central authority in Delhi.

Lodi Dynasty (1451 – 1526 CE)

Overview:

- The last dynasty of the Delhi Sultanate, founded by **Bahlul Lodi**.
- The only **Afghan dynasty** to rule Delhi.

Key Rulers:

- **Bahlul Lodi (1451–1489):** Founder, consolidated power.
- **Sikandar Lodi (1489–1517):** Expanded empire, founded **Agra** as capital, promoted agriculture.
- **Ibrahim Lodi (1517–1526):** Last Sultan; unpopular with nobles. Defeated by **Babur** in the **First Battle of Panipat (1526 CE)**, marking the end of Delhi Sultanate and start of Mughal rule.

Vijayanagara Empire (1336 – 1646 CE)

Overview:

- A strong **Hindu kingdom in South India**, founded by **Harihara and Bukka** of the Sangama dynasty (1336 CE).
- Flourished as a center of **trade, culture, and Hindu revival**.

Key Rulers:

- **Krishnadevaraya (1509–1529 CE):** Greatest ruler.
    - Expanded empire.
    - Patron of art, literature, and architecture.
    - Wrote *Amuktamalyada* in Telugu.
    - Defeated Bahmani successors and ruled peak empire.
- Empire declined after **Battle of Talikota (1565 CE)**, where combined Deccan sultanates defeated Vijayanagara.
- Survived in weakened form till mid-17th century.

Bahmani Sultanate (1347 – 1527 CE)

Overview:

- First independent Muslim kingdom in the Deccan, founded by **Ala-ud-Din Bahman Shah** (1347 CE).
- Capital: **Gulbarga** (later Bidar).

Features:

- Rival of Vijayanagara Empire.
- Promoted Persian culture, architecture, Indo-Islamic traditions.
- Encouraged irrigation and agriculture.
- After 1527, split into **five Deccan Sultanates**: Bijapur, Golconda, Ahmadnagar, Bidar, Berar.

Barid Shahi of Bidar (1489 – 1619 CE)

Overview:

- One of the **five Deccan Sultanates** formed after Bahmani decline.
- Based at **Bidar**.
- Weaker compared to Bijapur and Golconda.

Decline:

- Annexed by the **Adil Shahi Sultanate of Bijapur** in 1619.